Shaul Tchernichovsky, *עלילות גלגמש* (Warsaw: Stybel, 1924) – Hebrew verse translation

▼ **Contents**

Files 1
Line numbering 1
Name forms used (with niqqud) 1
Assessment 2

- **Translator:** Shaul Tchernichovsky (שאול טשרניחובסקי, 1875–1943). The translation was made **from German**, not from Akkadian. Ben-Yehuda labels it "תרגום: שאול טשרניחובסקי (מגרמנית)". Simchoni's introduction names Jensen and Ungnad (1911) as the available translations, and says G. E. Burckhardt's German retelling "became the model for all new translators". Hebrew Wikipedia (citing Sh. Shifra 2004) also says "from German".
- **Original edition:** Warsaw: A. J. Stybel, תרפ"ד (1924), with an introduction by Jacob Naftali Simchoni (יעקב נפתלי שמחוני). Reprinted in כתבי שאול טשרניחובסקי, vol. 6 (שירות ושירים), Tel Aviv: Am Oved, 1990 (Ben-Yehuda gives תש"ן; Hebrew Wikipedia gives 1995).
- **URLs:**
    - Project Ben-Yehuda, whole work: https://benyehuda.org/read/8062 (in the cycle "משירת הבבלים", collection https://benyehuda.org/collections/3439)
    - Simchoni's introduction: https://benyehuda.org/read/50136
    - Hebrew Wikisource, Tablet XI (same Am Oved text, independent transcription): https://he.wikisource.org/wiki/כל_כתבי_שאול_טשרניחובסקי/כרך_ו'%3A_שירות_ושירים/עלילות_גלגמש/לוח_אחד_עשר
- **Retrieved:** 2026-10-16
- **License / copyright: Public domain** (Ben-Yehuda: "נחלת הכלל"; translator died 1943; Simchoni died 1926).

Files

- `benyehuda-read-8062.raw.html`: raw page (whole epic, all 12 tablets).
- `full-work--all-tablets.rtl.md`: clean extraction of the whole page (includes site chrome at top and bottom).
- `tablet-XI.rtl.md`: **Tablet XI only**, one verse per line, niqqud exactly as in source. It also has the edition's name glossary (השמות) and all 5 footnotes (`^n`).
- `he.wikisource--luach-11.wikitext.rtl.txt`: raw wikitext of Tablet XI from Hebrew Wikisource. Useful to cross-check niqqud and typos. It uses ASCII hyphen "-" where Ben-Yehuda uses maqaf "־".
- `benyehuda-read-50136--Simchoni-intro.raw.html`, `Simchoni-introduction-1924.rtl.md`: Simchoni's 1924 introduction. It covers the history of decipherment (Smith, Haupt, Jensen, Ungnad), a tablet-by-tablet literary discussion, and Bible parallels.

Line numbering

There are **no line numbers** in the source. Tablet XI has 354 verse lines in Tchernichovsky's version (vs. 328 Akkadian lines in George), because his German source paraphrases and splits lines. Align by content.

Name forms used (with niqqud)

אוּת־נַפִּשְׁתִּים (Ūta-napišti; glossary: "הוא שמצא את החיים"), אֵאָה (Ea), אֶנְלִיל (Enlil), אַנוּ (Anu), נִינִיב (= Ninurta, old reading "Ninib"), אֱנוּגִי (Ennugi), שׁוּרִיפַּק (Šuruppak), אוּבָּרָה־תּוּתוּ (Ubar-Tutu), פּוּזוּר־אָמוּרִי (Puzur-Amurri, the boatman), הַר־נִיסִיר (Mt Niṣir = Nimuš), אֲדַד (Adad), שַׁמַשׁ (Šamaš), עִשְׁתָּר (Ištar; Bēlet-ilī = "גְּבֶרֶת־הָאֵלִים"), אִירְגַל (Erragal), הָאֲנוּנָּקִים

(Anunnaki), אוּר־שַׁנַבִּי (Ur-šanabi). Simchoni's intro writes אֻתְ־נַפִּשְׁתִּים.

Assessment

A literary classic, not a philological translation. It is a rich biblical-style Hebrew poem ("וַיִּפְתַּח אֵאָה אֶת־פִּיהוּ", "סֻכַּת־קָנֶה! ... כֹּתֶל!", "וָאֲשַׁלַּח אֶת־הָעוֹרֵב") that deliberately echoes Genesis 6–9. It is valuable for Hebrew register and diction, and as the canonical earlier Hebrew rendering readers know. It is **unreliable on content**:

- It is second-hand (from German) and based on 1900–1916 readings, with paraphrastic additions.
- Old name forms (Ninib, Nisir, Puzur-Amurri).
- At George XI 199 ff. it has **Ea** (not Enlil) board the ship and bless the couple.
- Atra-hasis is rendered "רַב־הַחָכְמָה" (a literal etymology of the name).
- Gaps are filled silently.

Do not use it as evidence for what the Akkadian says.